



IV MUN  
2026

# IV MUN 2026

INSPIRE • NEGOTIATE • LEAD



United Nations Entity for Gender Equality  
and the Empowerment of Women

LET HER  
DREAM,  
NOT  
MARRY.

HER FUTURE  
IS NOT  
FOR SALE.

CHILDHOOD  
NOT  
WIFEHOOD.

## AGENDA:

# ELIMINATING CHILD MARRIAGE AND FORCED MARRIAGE WORLDWIDE

## COMMITTEE OBJECTIVES



### PROTECT GIRLS' RIGHTS

Uphold the rights, dignity and freedom of every girl, ensuring her right to childhood, education and life without violence.



### EMPOWER GIRLS

Promote education, skills development and economic empowerment to enable girls to make informed life choices.



### ELIMINATE HARMFUL PRACTICES

End child marriage and forced marriage in all forms through legal reform, prevention and community transformation.



### STRENGTHEN LAWS & POLICIES

Advocate for strong legal frameworks and effective enforcement to protect girls and hold perpetrators accountable.



### BUILD A JUST & EQUAL WORLD

Advance gender equality and create societies where every girl can live with freedom, equality and opportunity.



“ A girl should be two things:  
who and what she wants.”

– Coco Chanel



“ When you invest in girls, you invest in the future.”  
Let us unite to end child marriage and forced marriage  
and build a world where every girl can choose her own path.  
– UN Women



EDUCATE



EMPOWER



PROTECT



EQUALITY



# UNDERSTANDING UN WOMEN

**UN Women** is the UN entity dedicated to gender equality and the empowerment of women. It works worldwide to eliminate discrimination, empower women, and achieve equality as partners in development, humanitarian action, and peace and security.



## HISTORY

- 1946**  
The UN Charter reaffirms faith in fundamental human rights and in the equal rights of men and women.
- 1975**  
International Women's Year and the first World Conference on Women (Mexico City).
- 1976-1985**  
UN Decade for Women: Equality, Development and Peace.
- 2010**  
UN Women was established by UN General Assembly resolution 64/289 on 2 July 2010.
- 2011**  
UN Women became operational on 1 January 2011, bringing together four previously separate entities.

## MANDATE

UN Women's mandate is to champion gender equality and empower women as a universal human right, as well as a necessary foundation for a peaceful, prosperous and sustainable world.

- ✓ Support intergovernmental bodies in setting global standards.
- ✓ Assist Member States in implementing gender commitments.
- ✓ Coordinate UN system efforts on gender equality.
- ✓ Promote accountability and monitoring of gender equality.
- ✓ Mobilize resources for gender equality initiatives.

## MEMBERSHIP

**193****UN MEMBER STATES**

All UN Member States are part of UN Women.

**4****OBSERVER STATES**

Holy See, State of Palestine, Niue, Cook Islands.

**BROAD PARTNERSHIP**

Works with governments, civil society, the private sector, UN entities and regional organizations.

## ORGANIZATIONAL STRUCTURE

**Leadership & Management****Programme Division****Partnerships Division****Governance Division****Operations Division**

## DECISION-MAKING PROCESS

**1****Agenda Setting**

Issues are identified through global consultations, research, and reports.

**2****Discussion & Negotiation**

Member States deliberate in the Executive Board and intergovernmental forums.

**3****Consensus Building**

Decisions are ideally taken by consensus, reflecting the voices of all Member States.

**4****Decision & Approval**

Policies, strategies and resolutions are adopted or endorsed.

**5****Implementation & Review**

UN Women and partners implement decisions and report on progress.

## MAJOR FUNCTIONS



**Normative Support**  
Promotes global norms, standards and policies on gender equality.



**Operational Support**  
Supports countries in implementing laws, policies and services for women and girls.



**Coordination**  
Coordinates UN system activities on gender equality and strengthens coherence across the UN.



**Resource Mobilization**  
Mobilizes and manages resources to advance gender equality worldwide.



**Knowledge & Data**  
Generates data, research and knowledge to inform evidence-based decision-making.



**Advocacy & Partnerships**  
Builds partnerships and advocates for women's rights and gender equality at all levels.



## UN WOMEN ENTITIES (Before 2011)

- ✓ Division for the Advancement of Women (DAW)
- ✓ International Research and Training Institute for the Advancement of Women (INSTRAW)
- ✓ Office of the Special Adviser on Gender Issues (OSAGI)
- ✓ UN Development Fund for Women (UNIFEM)

These four entities were merged to form UN Women in 2010.



## REGIONAL OFFICES



- Americas and the Caribbean (Panama City)
- Europe and Central Asia (Istanbul)
- West and Central Africa (Dakar)
- East and Southern Africa (Nairobi)
- Asia and the Pacific (Bangkok)
- Arab States (Amman)



*“When you invest in girls, you invest in the future.”  
Let us unite to end child marriage and forced marriage  
and build a world where every girl can choose her own path.”*  
– UN Women





# BACKGROUND TO THE AGENDA: ELIMINATING CHILD MARRIAGE AND FORCED MARRIAGE WORLDWIDE

**“** Child marriage and forced marriage are not cultural inevitable—they are human rights violations. Ending them is not just possible, it is our collective duty. **”**

– UN Women

MY LIFE.  
MY CHOICE.  
MY FUTURE.



## WHAT IS CHILD MARRIAGE?



Child marriage is a formal marriage or informal union before the age of 18. It includes both girls and boys, though it disproportionately affects girls.

18 is the universally accepted minimum age for marriage under international law.



## WHAT IS FORCED MARRIAGE?



Forced marriage is a marriage in which one or both parties do not consent or cannot consent due to coercion, threats, violence, or manipulation.

It is a violation of human rights and a form of gender-based violence.



## GLOBAL SNAPSHOT (2025–2026)



**650 MILLION**

women alive today were married before the age of 18.



**12 MILLION**

girls are married before 18 EVERY YEAR.



**1 IN 5**

young women were married before their 18th birthday.



**1 IN 30**

girls are married before the age of 15.



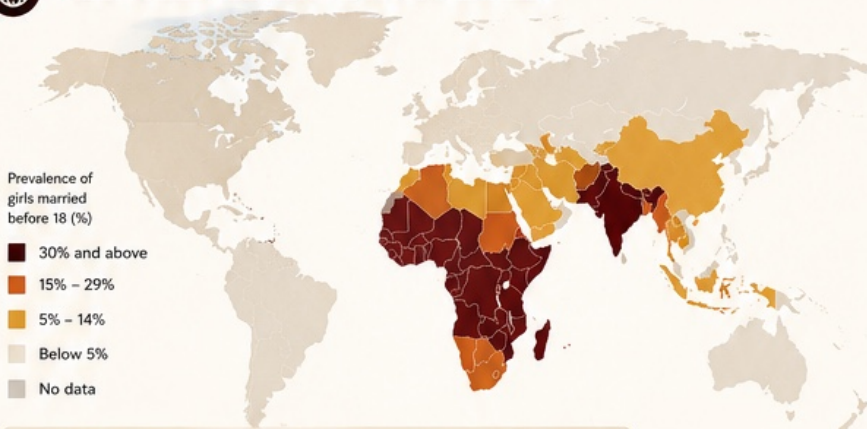
**90%**

of child marriages occur in low- and middle-income countries.

Source: UN Women (2025), UNICEF (2024), WHO (2024)



## WHERE CHILD MARRIAGE IS MOST PREVALENT



Sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia are the regions most affected, but child marriage exists in every region of the world.



## ROOT CAUSES

- **Poverty:** Families may see marriage as an economic survival strategy.
- **Lack of Education:** Girls with little or no education are at higher risk.
- **Social Norms & Traditions:** Harmful gender norms and traditions perpetuate early marriage.
- **Gender Inequality:** Discriminatory laws, practices and attitudes devalue girls.
- **Insecurity & Conflict:** Crises increase vulnerability and reduce protection for girls.
- **Dowry & Bride Price:** Financial incentives for families to marry off daughters early.



## HUMANITARIAN & DEVELOPMENT CONSEQUENCES



### Education Interrupted

Girls who marry early are more likely to drop out of school.



### Health Risks

Early pregnancy increases risks of maternal mortality, complications, and poor health outcomes.



### Economic Impact

Limits girls' future earning potential and perpetuates intergenerational poverty.



### Violence & Abuse

Girls in child marriage are more likely to experience domestic violence and abuse.



### Human Rights Violations

Denies girls their rights to education, health, freedom, and autonomy.



## TIMELINE: KEY MILESTONES IN GLOBAL ACTION

- **1990** World Declaration on the Survival, Protection and Development of Children (Jomtien, Thailand)
- **1995** Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action – calls for action to end harmful practices including child marriage.
- **2000** Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) adopted – Goal 3: Promote gender equality and empower women.
- **2015** Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) adopted – Goal 5.3 aims to eliminate all harmful practices, including child, early and forced marriage.
- **2016** UN General Assembly declares 11 October as the International Day of the Girl Child.
- **2020** UNFPA–UNICEF Global Programme to End Child Marriage launched to accelerate action in 12 high-prevalence countries.
- **2025+** Renewed global commitments to end child marriage by 2030 through the Generation Equality Agenda.



## KEY TAKEAWAY

Child marriage and forced marriage rob millions of girls of their childhood, their rights, and their future. Eliminating these practices is essential to achieving gender equality, sustainable development, and inclusive societies where every girl can live with dignity and choice.



**“** No girl should be denied her rights, her education, her health, or her dreams because she was born a girl. **”**

– UN Women



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# INTERNATIONAL LEGAL FRAMEWORK

PROTECTING GIRLS. UPHOLDING RIGHTS. ENSURING JUSTICE.

“ Laws and policies are powerful tools to end child marriage and forced marriage—when they are implemented, resourced, and monitored for every girl, everywhere. ”

– UN Women

NO MORE  
SILENCE.  
END CHILD  
MARRIAGE.

EQUALITY  
BEGINS  
WITH HER.



## KEY INTERNATIONAL LEGAL INSTRUMENTS



**CEDAW**  
(1979)

The Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women obliges States to take all appropriate measures to eliminate discrimination and ensure equality in marriage and family relations.

**Key Articles:**  
2, 5(a), 16



**CRC**  
(1989)

The Convention on the Rights of the Child sets 18 as the minimum age for marriage and protects children from all forms of physical or mental violence, coercion, and exploitation.

**Key Articles:**  
3, 19, 24, 34



**UDHR**  
(1948)

The Universal Declaration of Human Rights affirms the right to marry freely and with full consent (Art. 16) and the right to life, liberty, security and equality before the law (Arts. 1, 3, 7).

**Key Articles:**  
1, 3, 16



**SDG 5.3**  
(2030 Agenda)

Calls for the elimination of all harmful practices, such as child, early and forced marriage and female genital mutilation, by 2030.

**Indicator:**  
5.3.1 – Proportion of women aged 20–24 married or in union before age 18.



**Beijing Declaration & Platform for Action**  
(1995)

Recognizes that gender inequality and harmful traditional practices, including early and forced marriage, are violations of human rights.

**Critical Areas:**  
A (Women & Poverty), F (Women & Human Rights), L (Girl Child)



**Other Relevant Instruments**

- ICCPR (Art. 23)
- ICESCR (Art. 10)
- African Charter on the Rights and Welfare of the Child (Art. 21)
- Arab Charter on Human Rights (Art. 27)



## KEY STAKEHOLDERS & PARTNERS



**UN Women**

Leads global efforts to end child marriage and forced marriage through policy support, advocacy, programmes, and partnerships.



**UNICEF**

Works to protect children's rights, provide education, social protection and prevent harmful practices.



**UNFPA**

Supports sexual and reproductive health, empowers young people and funds initiatives to end child marriage.



**Governments**

Enact and enforce laws, develop national action plans, allocate resources and ensure accountability.



**NGOs & Civil Society**

Implement community programmes, grassroots advocacy, survivor support and awareness campaigns.



**Religious & Traditional Leaders**

Influence social norms and beliefs; can be powerful allies in promoting girls' rights and ending harmful practices.



**Community Organizations**

Drive local change, engage families, support girls' education and monitor protection mechanisms.



**Private Sector**

Promotes girls' education, economic empowerment and ethical business practices.



**Youth & Adolescent Girls**

Leading change as advocates, peer educators and change-makers in their communities.



## KEY IMPLEMENTATION CHALLENGES



**Deep-rooted Social Norms**

Patriarchal norms and traditions continue to normalize child marriage and limit girls' choices.



**Weak Laws & Poor Enforcement**

Many countries lack a minimum legal age of marriage or fail to enforce existing laws.



**Poverty & Economic Inequality**

Families may marry off girls to reduce financial burden or secure economic protection.



**Lack of Education**

Girls out of school are more likely to be married early and have limited opportunities.



**Conflict & Fragility**

Emergencies increase vulnerability to early and forced marriage through displacement, insecurity and disrupted services.



**Lack of Data & Monitoring**

Insufficient data and weak monitoring hinder effective policy planning and accountability.



**Limited Support Services**

Survivors often lack access to legal aid, healthcare, shelters and psychosocial support.



**Cross-border & Migration Factors**

Displacement, trafficking and migration increase risks of forced marriage.



Ending child marriage and forced marriage requires laws, resources, accountability and social transformation—together.



## WHY IT MATTERS



**Protects Human Rights**

Upholds girls' rights to life, liberty, dignity, education and health.



**Improves Health Outcomes**

Delays pregnancy, reduces maternal mortality and improves mental health.



**Promotes Education & Empowerment**

Educated girls are more likely to earn, lead and make informed life choices.



**Strengthens Economies**

Empowered women contribute to economic growth and poverty reduction.



**Builds Peaceful & Inclusive Societies**

Gender equality fosters social cohesion, justice and sustainable development.



“ When girls are empowered, societies thrive. When girls are married as children, we all lose. ”

– UN Women



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# COMMITTEE PREPARATION: DEBATE. NEGOTIATE. IMPACT.

Effective preparation leads to meaningful debate and impactful solutions. Understand your position, build alliances, and work towards a future free from child marriage and forced marriage.



## BLOC POSITIONS

| BLOC                                                                                                                | GENERAL POSITION                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|  Western European and Others (WEOG) | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Strongly support eliminating child marriage and forced marriage.</li><li>Emphasize legal reforms, education and economic empowerment.</li><li>Advocate for data collection and accountability.</li></ul>         |
|  African Group                      | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Support the elimination of harmful practices but emphasize cultural sensitivity.</li><li>Focus on education, poverty reduction and community engagement.</li><li>Seek financial and technical support.</li></ul> |
|  Asia-Pacific Group                 | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Support ending child marriage and forced marriage.</li><li>Stress national sovereignty and context-specific solutions.</li><li>Highlight education, economic development and social protection.</li></ul>        |
|  Eastern European Group            | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Support strong legal frameworks and alignment with international standards.</li><li>Emphasize data, monitoring and regional cooperation.</li></ul>                                                               |
|  GRULAC                           | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Support elimination through human rights and gender equality lens.</li><li>Emphasize prevention, education and empowerment of girls.</li><li>Call for inclusive and participatory approaches.</li></ul>          |
|  LMDCs                            | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>Prioritize development assistance, education and poverty alleviation.</li><li>Seek capacity-building and resources for implementation.</li><li>Stress the need for international cooperation.</li></ul>          |



## RESOLUTION WRITING: QUICK GUIDE



### Preambulatory Clauses

Set the context and acknowledge existing efforts and challenges.



### Operative Clauses

Present actionable solutions and concrete steps.



### Clear & Specific Language

Use precise language, avoid ambiguous terms.



### Action-Oriented

Focus on what the committee can realistically implement.



### Balance & Inclusivity

Ensure clauses consider diverse contexts and are inclusive.



## SAMPLE OPERATIVE CLAUSES

- 1 Calls upon Member States to set and enforce a minimum legal age of marriage of 18 without exception.
- 2 Urges Member States to ensure free and quality education for all girls, especially in vulnerable communities.
- 3 Encourages comprehensive community awareness and behavior change programs to address harmful social norms.
- 4 Requests UN Women and partners to support economic empowerment initiatives for girls and young women.
- 5 Invites Member States to strengthen data collection and monitoring on child marriage and forced marriage.
- 6 Calls for increased funding and resources to support prevention, protection and survivor services.



Good resolutions don't just react to problems—they create pathways to a better future.



## DEBATE STRATEGY



### Know Your Country

Understand your country's laws, statistics and national initiatives.



### Build Alliances

Identify like-minded countries and work within and across blocs.



### Listen Actively

Engage with other delegates and respond constructively.



### Speak with Purpose

Be concise, respectful and solution-oriented.



### Use Data & Examples

Support your points with facts, real examples and case studies.



### Stay Solution-Focused

Avoid blame; propose practical and implementable solutions.



## POSSIBLE SOLUTIONS



Strengthen and enforce laws setting minimum age of marriage at 18.



Ensure universal access to quality education for girls.



Empower girls economically through skills training and job opportunities.



Engage communities and religious leaders to change harmful social norms.



Provide safe spaces and support services for at-risk girls and survivors.



Invest in data systems, research and monitoring to track progress.



Increase funding and partnerships for prevention and response programs.



## KEY MOTIONS DELEGATES SHOULD KNOW



### Point of Order

To raise a procedural issue.



### Point of Information

To request clarification.



### Right of Reply

To respond to personal remarks.



### Motion to Amend

To propose changes to a clause.



### Motion to Divide the Question

To separate parts of a resolution.



### Motion to Close Debate

To end debate and move to voting.



### Motion for Moderated Caucus

To hold informal discussions with time limits.



Use motions wisely. They are tools for effective procedure and productive debate.



## DELEGATE CHECKLIST

- ☐ Research my country's laws and policies.
- ☐ Understand the root causes and impacts.
- ☐ Review UN Women's and UN reports.
- ☐ Identify potential allies and partners.
- ☐ Prepare facts, statistics and examples.
- ☐ Draft possible solutions and clauses.
- ☐ Practice my opening speech.
- ☐ Be respectful, inclusive and solution-oriented.
- ☐ Stay informed and adaptable.



## OPENING SPEECH GUIDE



1 Greet the Chair and fellow delegates.



2 Introduce your country.



3 State your position on the agenda.



4 Highlight key concerns and challenges.



5 Present your vision and commitment to ending child marriage and forced marriage.



A strong opening sets the tone for meaningful dialogue and leadership.

“The best investment we can make is in girls and women. When girls are empowered, societies thrive.”

– UN Women



“When you invest in girls, you invest in the future. Let us unite to end child marriage and forced marriage and build a world where every girl can choose her own path.”  
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# APPENDIX & QUICK REFERENCE

## KNOWLEDGE. PREPARATION. IMPACT.

“When you invest in girls, you invest in the future.  
Let us unite to end child marriage and forced marriage  
and build a world where every girl can choose her own path.”

– UN Women

”



### IMPORTANT TREATIES & AGREEMENTS



#### CEDAW (1979)

The cornerstone treaty for gender equality and the elimination of discrimination against women.



#### CRC (1989)

Protects children's rights, including the right to be protected from all forms of harm and exploitation.



#### ICCPR (1966)

Protects the right to consent to marriage and to equality before the law.



#### Maputo Protocol (2003)

African Charter on Human and Peoples' Rights on the Rights of Women in Africa; sets 18 as minimum age of marriage.



#### Sustainable Development Goals (2015)

SDG 5.3 commits to eliminate all harmful practices, including child, early and forced marriage by 2030.



### KEY TERMINOLOGY

- **Child Marriage:** Marriage or union before 18 years of age.
- **Forced Marriage:** Marriage entered into without the free and full consent of one or both parties.
- **Consent:** Freely given, informed and reversible agreement to marry.
- **Early Marriage:** Marriage before the age of 18, with or without consent.
- **Harmful Practice:** A practice that causes physical, mental or social harm to individuals or communities.
- **Survivor:** A person who has experienced child marriage or forced marriage.
- **Intersectionality:** Recognizing how overlapping factors like gender, poverty, ethnicity and disability increase vulnerability.



### TIMELINE OF INTERNATIONAL ACTION

- **1948** Universal Declaration of Human Rights affirms equality and dignity for all.
- **1979** CEDAW adopted.
- **1989** Convention on the Rights of the Child adopted.
- **1995** Beijing Declaration highlights harmful traditional practices.
- **2000** Millennium Development Goal 3 promotes gender equality and empowerment.
- **2015** SDG 5.3 adopted to end child marriage and harmful practices.
- **2021** Generation Equality Forum calls for accelerated action.
- **2025+** Renewed global commitments to end child marriage by 2030.



### RESEARCH CHECKLIST

- ☐ Understand child marriage and forced marriage definitions and forms.
- ☐ Study global and regional statistics and trends.
- ☐ Analyze root causes and drivers.
- ☐ Review international legal frameworks.
- ☐ Examine UN Women's programs and initiatives.
- ☐ Identify your country's laws, policies and challenges.
- ☐ Explore successful interventions and best practices.
- ☐ Find recent reports, data and case studies.
- ☐ Prepare solution-oriented and realistic proposals.
- ☐ Stay updated on current developments.



### DELEGATE REMINDERS

- ✓ Listen actively and respect all viewpoints.
- ✓ Focus on solutions, not blame.
- ✓ Use facts, data and credible sources.
- ✓ Be inclusive, gender-sensitive and culturally aware.
- ✓ Work for consensus and common ground.
- ✓ Consider the needs of the most vulnerable.
- ✓ You represent your nation, but you serve the global community.



Diplomacy is the voice of reason, empathy and collective progress.



### USEFUL FACTS & STATISTICS (2025–2026)



#### 650 MILLION

women alive today were married before the age of 18.



#### 12 MILLION

girls are married before 18 EVERY YEAR.



#### 1 IN 5

young women were married before their 18th birthday.



#### 1 IN 30

girls are married before the age of 15.



#### 90%

of child marriages occur in low- and middle-income countries.

Sources: UN Women (2025), UNICEF (2024), WHO (2024)



### KEY AREAS FOR FURTHER RESEARCH



**Legal Reforms**  
Minimum age of marriage laws and enforcement challenges.



**Education**  
Keeping girls in school as a proven strategy to delay marriage.



**Economic Empowerment**  
Skills training, financial inclusion and livelihood opportunities for girls and women.



**Community Engagement**  
Involving men, boys, religious and community leaders to change social norms.



**Survivor Support**  
Access to healthcare, legal aid, counseling and safe spaces.



### FINAL MESSAGE

Child marriage and forced marriage are not just issues of the past—they are urgent challenges of today and obstacles to a just and equal world.

Together, we can build a future where every girl is valued, every woman is empowered, and every voice is heard.

Let us lead with compassion, courage and commitment.



“Empowered girls empower generations.  
A world without child marriage is a world of equal possibilities.”

– UN Women



One voice. One vision.  
A future without child marriage.

– UN Women



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LEAD



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